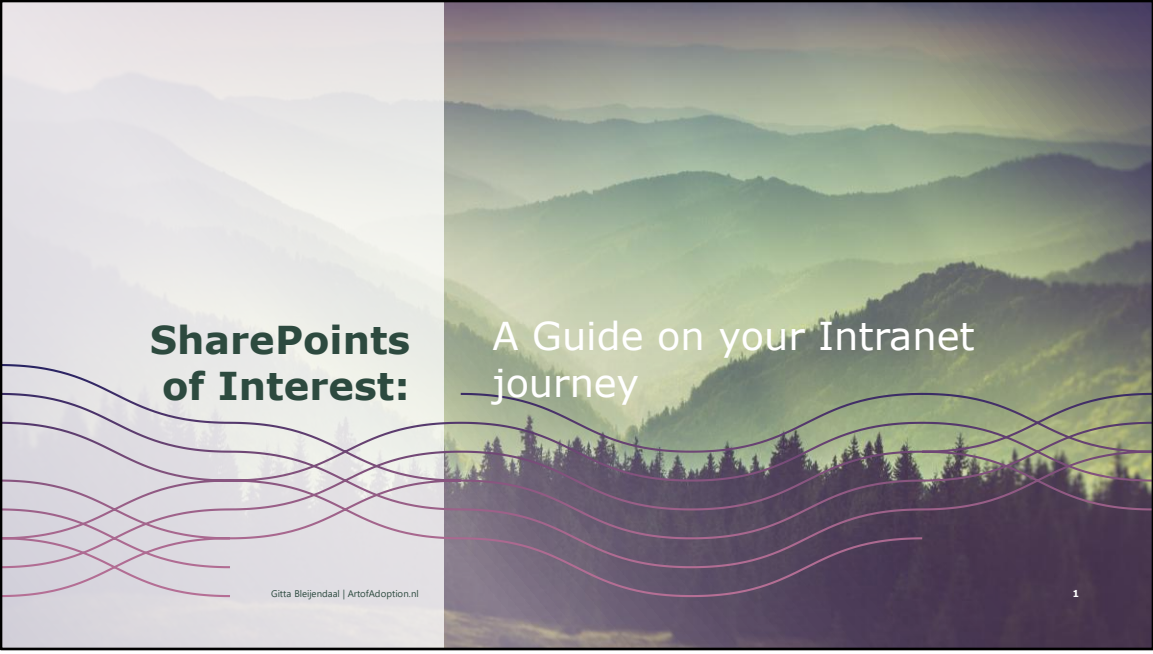




SharePoints of Interest:

A Guide on your Intranet
journey

Gitta Bleijendaal | AntofAdoption.nl

1

Introduction

- Gitta Bleijendaal
- Adoption Consultant @ PQR
- Functional Consultant @ PQR

Stats:

- 1 Husband
- 2 Fluffy cats
- 3rd degree black belt Shotokan Karate
- 1st degree black belt Ryu Kyu Kobujutsu
- Reading, Writing, Playing Violin, Painting, Leather crafting, Board Games, Gaming and then some 😊
- Blog: ArtofAdoption.nl

Gitta Bleijendaal | ArtofAdoption.nl



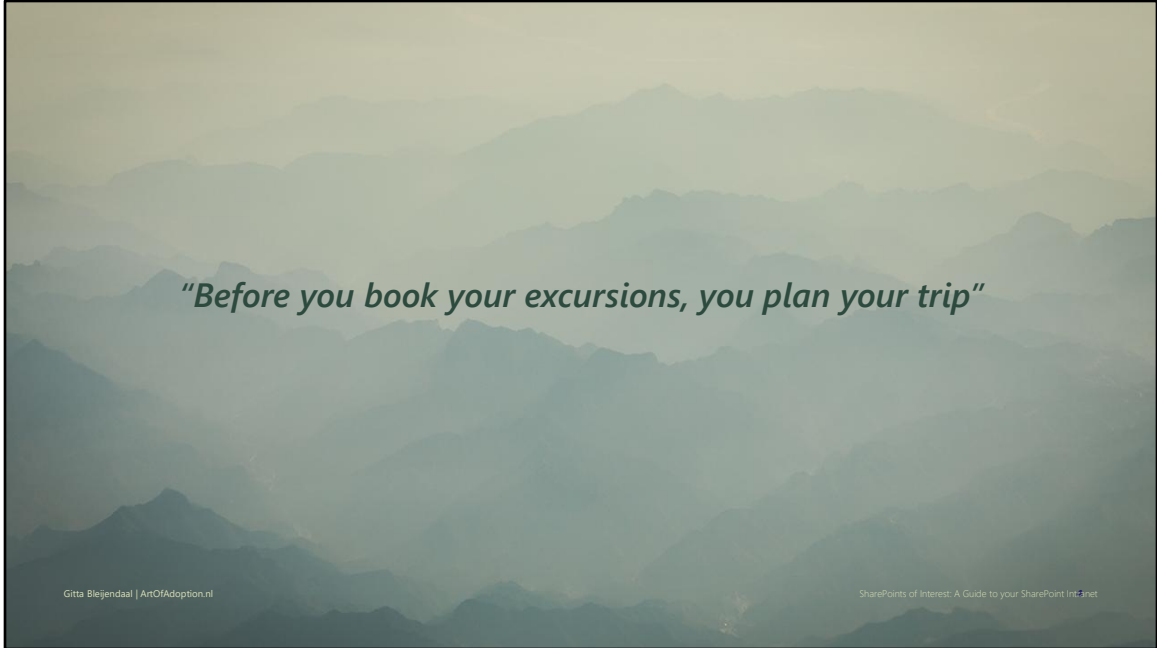
Guide's contents:

1. Start planning your trip
 - About goals, processes and ROIs
2. Choosing your SharePoints of Interest
 - Recommended key landmarks & new SharePoint highlights
3. Pack for your trip & make it last
 - Governance & lifecycle planning keep your Intranet journey fresh
4. Let's walk this journey together!
 - Recap for a modern, Copilot-ready intranet that aligns tech, people and processes.

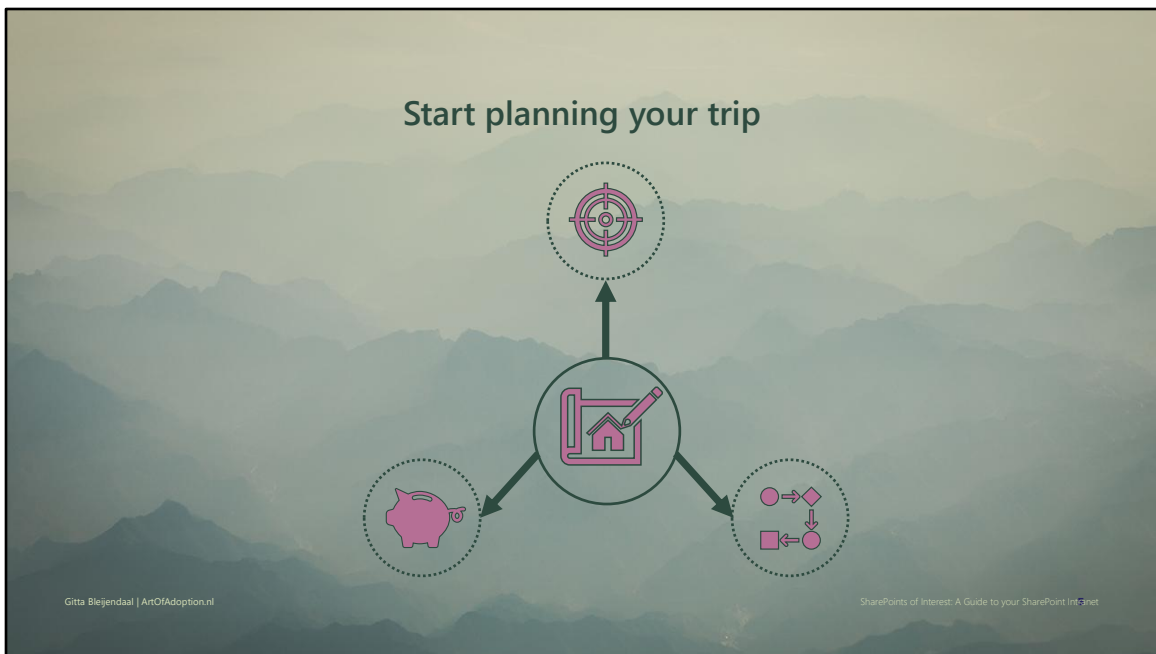
Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet





- Your intranet is no different: Without:
 - Clear goals
 - Strong processes and a
 - Realistic view on ROI, even the most beautiful SharePoint intranet will lose it's way.
- And Copilot will only amplify every mistake along that road.



So let's plan this trip and start asking yourself these questions first:

1. Goals → Why are you (re)building your intranet?
2. Processes → How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?
3. ROI → How do you justify and sustain your intranet?

1. Planning your trip | Goals

"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"



Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

Goals: Why are you (re)building your intranet? → Let's take a look at:

1. Business goals versus platform goals
2. Audience clarity
3. Social & engagement goals
4. AI-readiness as a goal
5. Success definition

With these 5 topics in mind: let's take a quick peek into planning our Intranet trip.

"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"

Planning | Business goals versus Platform goals

1. Is your intranet meant to:

1. Inform?
2. Connect people?
3. Support daily work?
4. Drive culture?
5. Enable AI (Copilot?)

"SharePoint is the means, not the goal"



Gita Brijendal / AnDIAAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

7

- Clearly define your goals and scope of your SharePoint intranet implementation.
- Ask yourself: What your intranet is support to do?
 - Inform?
 - Connect?
 - Support?
 - Drive?
 - Enable?
- Align these platform goals with your business objectives.

Setting goals not only help keep track of the why, but also determine a great part of the how: The eventual structure and content of your Intranet
Keep in mind that SharePoint is the means, not the goal.

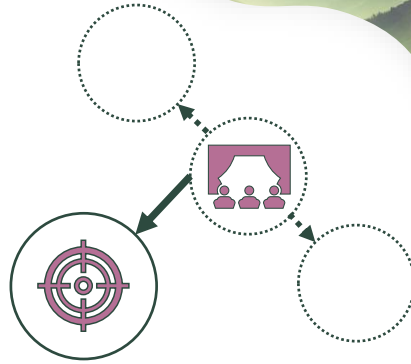
"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"

Planning | Audience clarity

2. Who is your intranet really for?

1. All employees?
2. Frontline versus office staff?
3. New hires versus experienced employees?

"One intranet does not equal one experience"



Gita Biscardi / AnGAAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

8

- In many intranet projects, the first assumption is "We are building ONE intranet for EVERYONE".
- That assumption is technically true, but experimentally wrong.
- The risks are: Content becomes generic Navigation becomes bloated Everyone gets "everything" AI (Copilot) surfaces irrelevant or confusing results

Clearly defining your Audience does not only make for a better suited intranet. Copilot relies on understanding WHO consumes WHAT KIND of content.

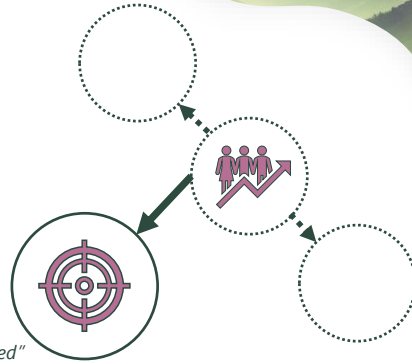
One intranet does not equal one experience: Even though an organization has one technical intranet platform, the way people experience that intranet is different for every group, role, and moment in their workday. Knowing your audience also helps build and deliver your intranet, both in structure and in content.

"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"

Planning | Social & engagement goals

3. What does "social" mean for your organization?

1. News commenting?
2. Communities?
3. Knowledge sharing?
4. Recognition?



"Social intranets fail when participation is assumed, not designed"

Gita Blijndael | AnDIAAdoptie.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

9

"Social intranets fail when participation is assumed, not designed"

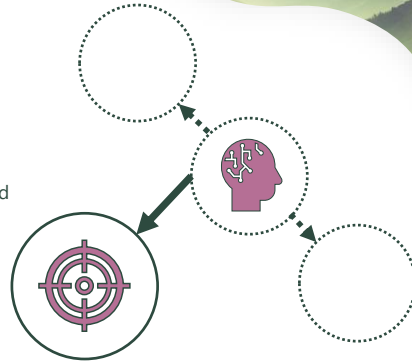
- Planning for social goals might also mean planning for additional tooling like apps from the Viva Platform

"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"

Planning | AI-readiness goals

4. Is Copilot an explicit driver, or an accidental by-product?

1. What kind of questions should Copilot be able to answer?
2. Where does trustworthy, authoritative content live?
3. Is your content structured well enough for AI to understand context?
4. Who owns the answers Copilot will generate?



"Are you intentionally designing your intranet so AI can work well, or did AI just show up and you hope for the best?"

Gita Bisland / AnGAAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

10

If you deliberately include Copilot as an explicit driver for your intranet, it becomes a reason to rethink or redesign your intranet.

In practice it means you design your intranet to:

- Reduce duplicate content
- Improve your Information Architecture
- Clarify your ownership and permissions
- Surface the RIGHT information to the RIGHT people

Only if you take these scenarios as design requirements and not as a surprise outcome, will Copilot become more accurate, will users trust the answers and will AI actually save time.

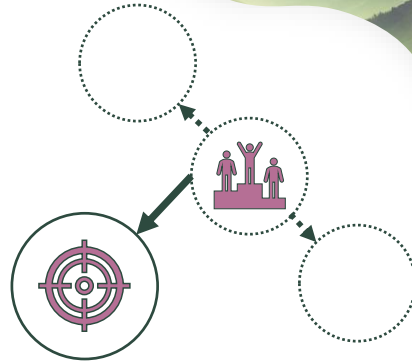
"Why are you (re)building your intranet?"

Planning | Success definition

5. What does a "successful intranet" look in 6 or 12 months?

1. Adoption?
2. Reduced mail?
3. Faster onboarding?
4. Better knowledge findability?

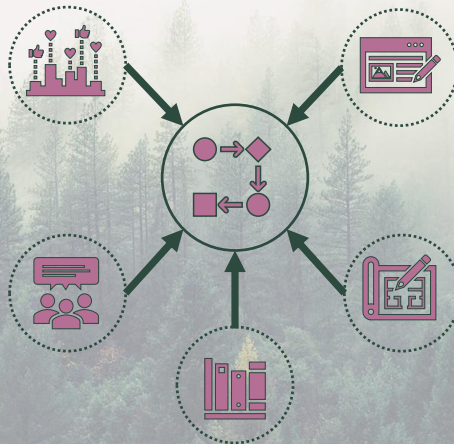
"Don't: We'll know it's successful when it's live"



"Going live" is but a step in the process. Success should be measurable and observational extracts of all the goals combined and held in the light of your audience.

2. Planning your trip | Processes

"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"



Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

12

Processes : How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant? → Let's take a look at:

1. Content ownership and lifecycle
2. Publishing and editorial processes
3. Information Architecture decisions
4. Adoption and Change approach
5. Feedback and iteration

With these 5 topics in mind: let's take a quick peek checking out how your intranet will keep up with it's users

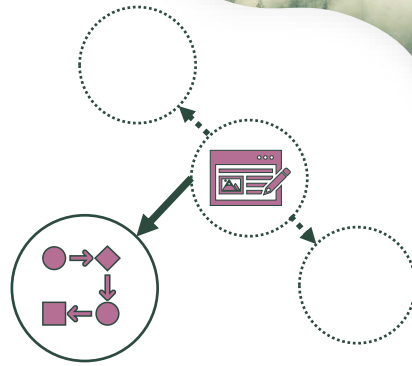
"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"

Planning | Content ownership & lifecycle

1. Key topics you must discuss and enable

1. Who owns content?
2. Who reviews it?
3. When does content expire?
4. How does content expire?

"Copilot won't question outdated content. People must"



Without either of these two, your intranet will quickly become redundant.

- Set rules to determine ownership, for instance: managers, project leads or team leads
- Reviews can be done by specialists for the topics: for instance, a manager or team lead can assign reviews to members of their teams
- Do documents (legally) require updates?
- Do you want to manually check outdated content, or set (semi)automated workflows?
- If you prethink content ownership and lifecycles, it is much easier to build your SharePoint intranet around these. For instance by building and enabling libraries around workflows based on owner and review cycles. You can go even beyond that by also enabling policies in Purview, but that's not on topic today.

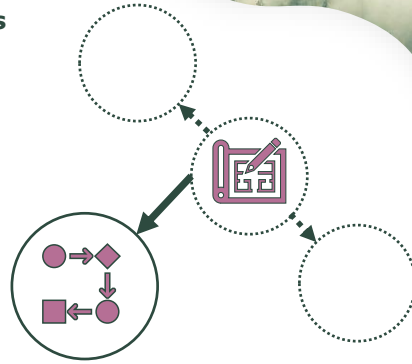
"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"

Planning | Publishing & editorial processes

2. Determine at least the following guiderails:

1. How is content created?
2. Who owns it? → don't: "IT must approve everything"
3. Who is the content for?
4. Content lifecycle → don't "we never delete anything"
5. Set: decentralized creation with clear boundaries

"Editorial processes don't equal bureaucracy, but guardrails"



In short: Guardrails are not walls. They don't stop you from driving, they stop you from driving off a cliff. And we don't want to fall of a cliff on this journey.

- When people hear "editorial process", they often think of approval chains, long review cycles, whether they can publish something or not, central team blocking progress and outdated content waiting for sign-off.
- This then leads to comments like "If we add editorial rules, nobody will contribute" and as a result, everything becomes open to everyone and to anything. Your structure disappears and your quality starts to vary wildly. It feels fast, but it creates long-term chaos.
- To prevent this, determine at least the following guiderails, to people can still move fast, but in the right direction.
 - For the sake of time: Examples will be given in my blogposts.

"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"

Planning | Information Architecture

3. A really, really brief overview, but keep in mind:

1. How is your content structured?
2. How is your content tagged, grouped?
3. Do you wish to use managed metadata?
4. Do you use personalized webparts?
5. Is your navigation built for humans, or for IT?



"IA is how Copilot understands context, not just content"

Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

15

The question: Is your navigation built for humans, or for IT highlights a common intranet pitfall: If users need to understand the platform to find information, the navigation is built for IT and not for humans.

- Many intranet navigation structures are shaped by technical or organizational logic, rather than by how people actually think, search, and work.
 - **Navigation built for IT** follows systems, site collections, permissions, or internal departments. It makes sense to the builders, but not necessarily to users.
 - **Navigation built for humans** reflects user language, tasks, and intent → helping people find what they need quickly without knowing how SharePoint is structured underneath.
- In the context of an AI-ready intranet, this matters even more: unclear or IT-centric navigation usually signals poor Information Architecture, which leads to confused users and less reliable Copilot answers.

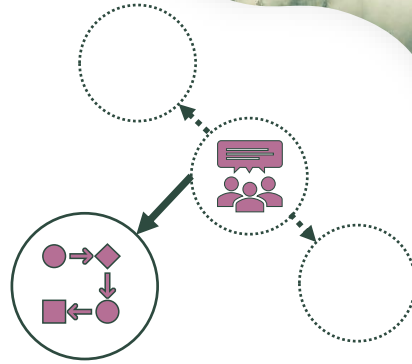
"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"

Planning | Adoption & Change approach

4. How do your users learn:

1. What's new?
2. Where to go?
3. How to contribute?
4. What their role is?

"Adoption is not a training once, it's an ongoing process"



- This is a topic in and of itself, but never forget people are part of your goals, your success, your content... They are your everything!

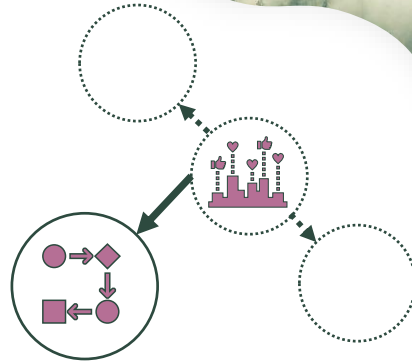
"How will your intranet live, grow and stay relevant?"

Planning | Feedback & Iteration

5. Ask yourself:

1. How do you know what works and what doesn't?
2. Do your users have voice, or just a search bar?

"Without feedback, no iteration. Without iteration, no intranet"



- Always plan iterations, make sure people have time in their agenda's to work on improvements
- Plan feedback moments, either or both mandatory and optional
- Always communicate and enable ways to give feedback to your users.

3. Planning your trip | ROI

"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"



Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

18

ROI : How will you justify and sustain your intranet?

Just like when you want to go on a business trip, someone in your organisation probably wants to know WHY an intranet is needed, in term of ROI

So let's briefly dive into the following topics:

1. ROI beyond money
2. Measuring usage versus impact
3. AI-driven ROI
4. Sustainability
5. Cost of not planning

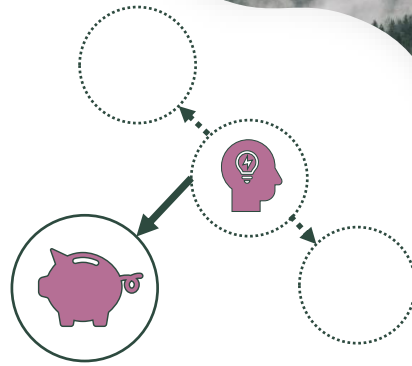
Let's take these 5 topics to the board and discuss some ROI points of Interest.

"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"

Planning | ROI beyond money

1. Determine your hard and soft ROI like:

1. Reduced support questions
2. Faster onboarding
3. Less duplicate content
4. Employee satisfaction
5. Trust in information
6. A place for culture and belonging



"Not everything valuable is easy to measure, but it is observable"

Gitte Blegen/SharePoint.com

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

19

1. Reduced support questions
2. Faster onboarding
3. Less duplicate content

Soft:

1. Employee satisfaction
2. Trust in information
3. A place for **culture** and belonging

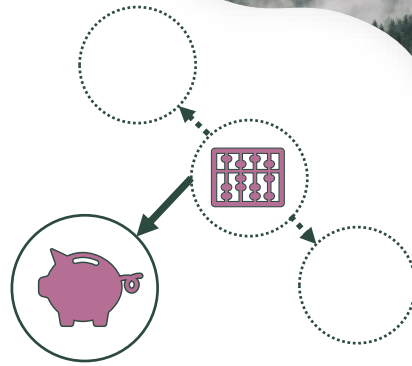
"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"

Planning | Measuring usage versus impact

2. For instance look at:

1. Returning users
2. Time to find information
3. Search success

"Page views don't equal value. Just because content is opened, doesn't mean it's useful"



Gitte Blegen/SharePoint

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

20

2. Measuring usage versus impact is important because:

- High page views may simply indicate confusion or repeated searching, while real value is shown by outcomes like users finding the right information faster, trusting the content, and successfully completing their tasks.
- Especially when Copilot relies on that content to give accurate answers.

So instead check for:

- Returning users
- Time to find information
- Search successes

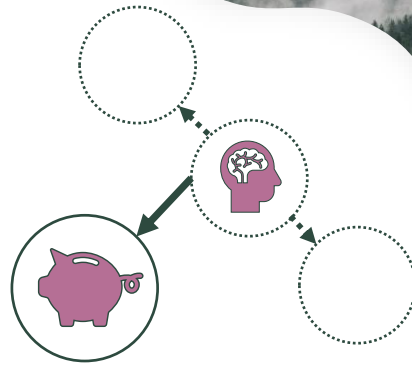
"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"

Planning | AI-driven ROI

3. For Copilot readiness always keep in mind:

1. Better IA makes better Copilot answers
2. Cleaner content means less hallucination risk
3. Clear ownership means having authoritative answers

"AI amplifies whatever foundation you already have"



Gitte Blegen/SharePoint.com

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

21

3. For Copilot readiness it keep in mind:

1. Better IA makes better Copilot answers
2. Cleaner content means less hallucination risk
3. Clear ownership means having authoritative answers

Tools like Copilot don't fix underlying intranet problems. They expose them. If your content, structure, and ownership are clear, AI makes them more valuable. If they're messy or outdated, AI spreads that confusion faster.

In other words, AI doesn't create quality, it multiplies what's already there. It why these steps of preparation are so important before you start building.

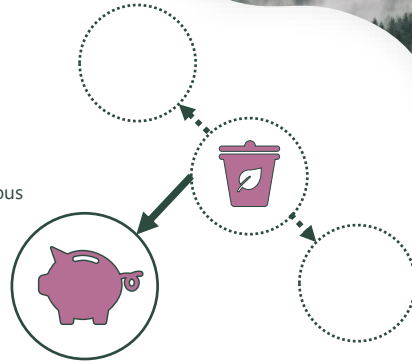
"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"

Planning | Sustainability

4. Plan for the future

1. Who maintains momentum after launch?
2. What happens after the first wave of enthusiasm?
3. Is there time, budget and ownership allocated for continuous maintenance and improvements?

"A good intranet is never done"



Gitte Blegen/SharePoint.com

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

22

4. Plan for the future.

Even before starting, take into account:

1. Who maintains momentum after launch?
2. What happens after the first wave of enthusiasm?
3. Is there time, budget and ownership allocated for continuous maintenance and improvements?

A good intranet is never done. Being done means content gets stale and eventually even your structures might not align with your organization anymore. Always plan for maintenance in both content, infrastructure and architecture. Keep Communication, IT and owners aligned.

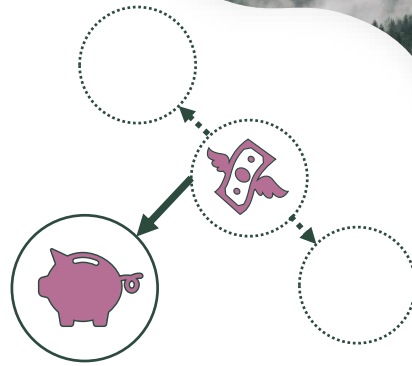
"How do you justify and sustain your intranet?"

Planning | Cost of not planning

5. Preparation isn't theoretical anymore, it should prevent:

1. Overloaded search results and too many helpdesk tickets
2. Inactive news pages and outdated content
3. Low trust in content
4. AI surfacing the wrong answers

"Poor preparation turns a great journey poor"



Gitte Blegen/SharePoint.com

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

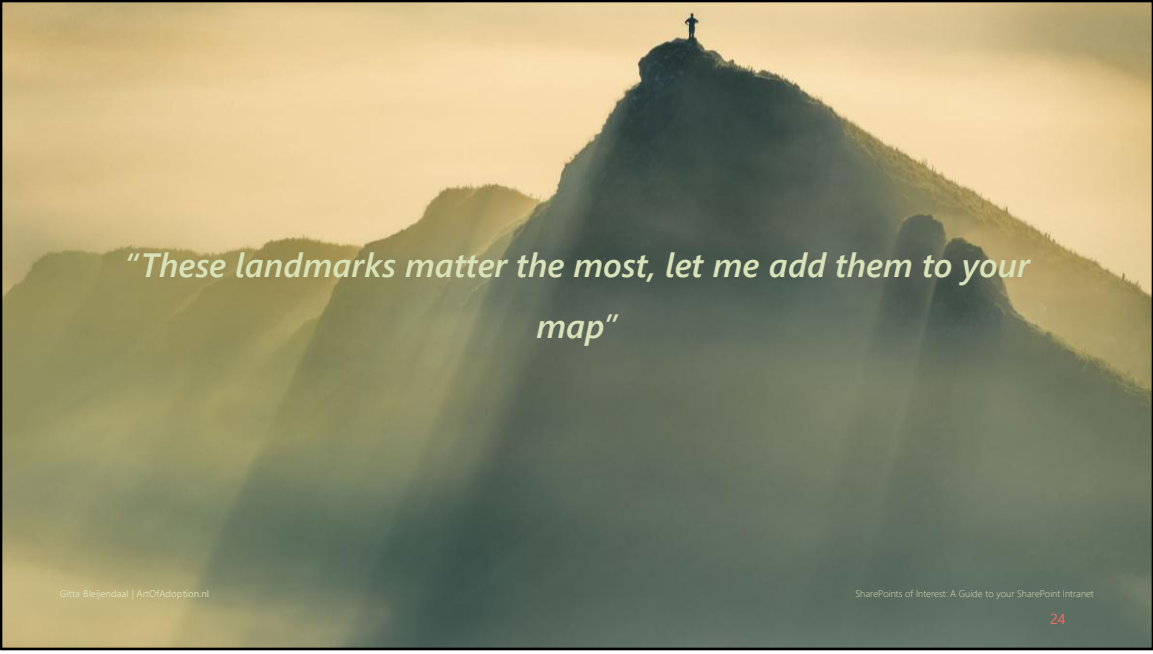
23

5. Cost of not planning

The real impact of preparation becomes unmistakably clear at this point.

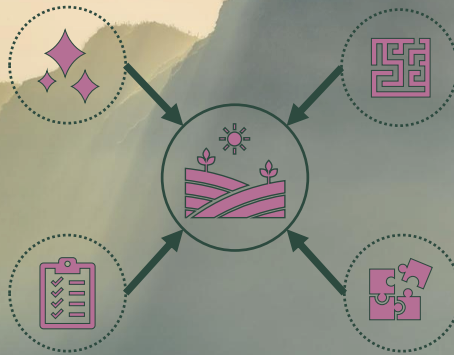
When you look at ROI, AI output, and day-to-day usability, it's obvious that poor goals, weak IA, and lack of adoption lead directly to confusion, low trust, and bad Copilot results.

By now, I hope preparation isn't theoretical anymore for your intranet.



"These landmarks matter the most, let me add them to your map"

Choosing your SharePoints of Interest



Gitta Bleijendaal | AnOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

25

Five foundational intranet tips we're gonna dive into:

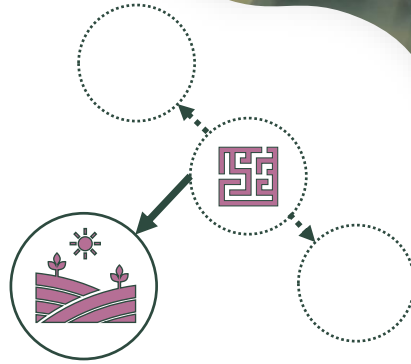
- 1. Design & Experience**
- 2. Core Features & Webparts**
- 3. Permissions & Metadata**
- 4. New & upcoming Features**

"These landmarks that matter the most"

Landmarks | Design

1. Information Architecture that supports people (and AI)

1. Sites are destinations, not containers
2. Pages support a specific need
3. Navigation aligned to user tasks
4. Audience targeting
5. Metadata as an invisible foundation



"Design for tasks, not structure. If users need to ask where something lives, your structure isn't working"

Gitta Biegemann | AmOAGroup.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

26

1. Sites should represent recognizable destinations like HR, IT, or Communities rather than just places where content happens to live. This helps users build a mental map of the intranet and it helps Copilot understand context and ownership.
 - Use hub sites to group related experiences.
2. Pages should exist to support a specific need: reading news, finding policies, completing a task, or learning something. When pages become generic or overloaded, users disengage and AI struggles to give meaningful answers.
 - Every page should answer a clear "Why would I open this?"
 - Needs could be: read, act, learn, decide.
 - A good page has one clear purpose, not five competing ones.
3. Navigation should reflect how users think and work, what they want to do and not how SharePoint is set up internally. If navigation is only based on departments, technical owners or legacy structures, users will rely on search, or give up.
 - Navigation could be seen as your first adoption tool, whether you intend it to be or not.
 - If users need to know your structure to navigate, the structure has

failed.

4. Use audience targeting for news, links and navigation. Audience targeting allows your intranet to serve different roles without fragmenting content. This keeps your intranet clear, reduces noise and improves trust. This is especially important when IT surfaces content automatically.
 - Keep in mind: Relevance drives engagement more than volume ever will.
 - One intranet can serve many experiences, if the relevance is intentional.
5. Columns, content types and managed metadata connects content across sites and supports filtering, search and Copilot answers. Without it, everything becomes a flat list of files that Copilot can't reliably interpret. AI doesn't really understand folders, it understands meaning and context. Simply put: AI doesn't care how nice your folders look, metadata gives it meaning.

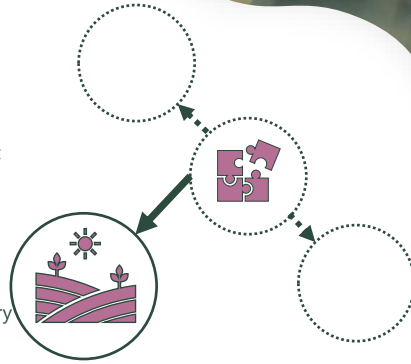
"These landmarks that matter the most"

Landmarks | Core features & web parts

2. Make your homepage an experience, not a dumping ground

1. Hero & Highlighted → Guide attention
2. News → Primary driver for communication & engagement
3. People & Viva web parts → Strengthen social layer
4. Quick links (done right) → Signposts for info
5. Search webpart → Support wayfinding
6. Document or Media Library → Content & Org. Asset Library

"Show people where to start, don't make them guess"



Gitta Biegemann | AmOAPerson.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

27

1. Hero & Highlighted content show people where to start, without making them guess or overwhelming them. They are both visually pleasing and guiding.
2. Fresh and relevant news makes users come back. Keep those guardrails in place to drive communication and engagement.
3. If your intranet is about people first, content second, you might consider the cost of Viva licenses to unlock its web parts, aside from the out-of-the-box people web part.
4. Quick links allow for task-oriented and role-based entry points. If done right, they are signposts to info, if done wrong, they become shortcuts to chaos.
 - Done wrong as an example: outdated links, links to links, links to outdated content
5. Support wayfinding without replacing navigation. PnP search parts can even elevate search (like people or content search) but keep in mind the amount configuration
6. Ye good ol' Library

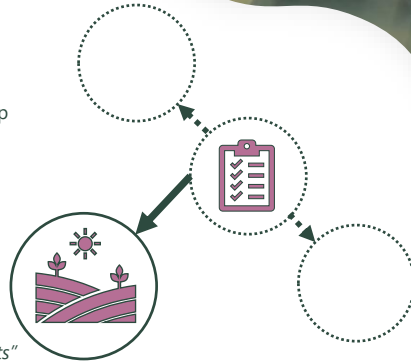
"These landmarks that matter the most"

Landmarks | Permissions & Metadata

3. Permissions & Metadata are part of UX – full stop

1. Access based on user expectations, not technical ownership
2. Keep permissions simple, predictable, role-based
3. Limit folder depth, avoid permission breaks
4. Use metadata to describe meaning, audience, relevance

"Permissions and metadata are core decisions, not afterthoughts"



Gitta Biegemann | AmOAGForum.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

28

3. What to keep in mind when designing your permissions & Metadata:

If users can't see what they expect and Copilot can't understand what it finds, the intranet will fail, no matter how good it looks.

1. Design access based on user expectations, not technical ownership Users expect to see content relevant to their role. It is why permissions should align with that mental model so access denials don't break trust.
2. Keep your permissions simple, predictable, and role-based Overly complex or inconsistent permission structures create confusion for users and unreliable signals for Copilot.
3. Limit your folder depth and avoid permission breaks at folder level. Deep folders and unique folder permissions hide content and make both navigation and AI reasoning harder.
4. Use metadata to describe meaning, audience, and relevance. Tags like topic, department, document type, or lifecycle status help users filter content and help Copilot understand context.

Treat metadata and permissions as core design decisions, not afterthoughts
When both are intentional from the start, users find what they expect and Copilot delivers answers they can trust.

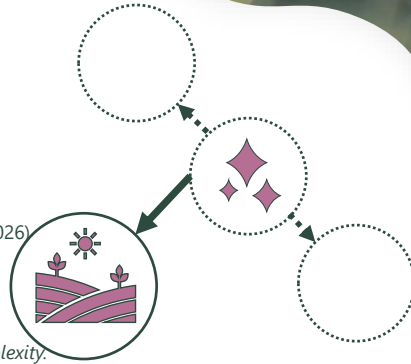
"These landmarks that matter the most"

Landmarks | New & upcoming features

4. Based on Ignite 2025 and the M365 / SharePoint roadmaps:

1. SharePoint Agents in Microsoft Teams (rollout early 2026)
2. Knowledge Agent for Intranet Content Cleanup (late 2025)
3. AI-Powered FAQ web part (rollout early-mid 2026)
4. Metadata-Aware Copilot Answers across Pages (expand. 2026)
5. M365 Archive: File-level archiving (rollout July 2026)
6. Ongoing focus

"Clarity beats customization. Simplicity scales better than complexity. SharePoint isn't just where content lives. It is how it is understood."



Gitta Biegemann | AmOceano.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

29

4. New and upcoming features as announced at Microsoft Ignite and/ or on the M365 roadmap/ SharePoint roadmap:

- **2026 isn't about adding more intranet features, but about whether your existing structure is good enough for AI to work with.**

1. **SharePoint Agents** allow users to interact with site-specific AI directly from Teams, asking questions grounded in intranet pages and documents. This matters because your intranet content becomes conversational and actionable without forcing your users to "go find" information
2. **The Knowledge Agent** helps identify outdated pages, missing content, broken links, and suggests metadata for better classification. This is important because AI surfaces problems faster. This feature helps you intranet owners to actively improve your quality instead of reacting to complaints
3. **AI-FAQ** This web part uses Copilot to automatically generate and maintain FAQs based on intranet content and documents. It improves discoverability and self-service, but also reinforces the need for authoritative, clearly owned content. → I have written a blogpost about the preview mode of this webpart

4. **Metadata-aware** Copilot increasingly reasons over SharePoint metadata and intranet pages, not just files.

Keep in mind: This elevates Information Architecture from “nice to have” to “critical foundation” for reliable AI responses.

5. **File-level archiving:** Allows individual files to be archived without archiving entire sites.

This helps your intranet stay lean and trustworthy by removing obsolete content from AI surfaces without destroying structure.

6. **Ongoing focus:** Microsoft has clearly positioned SharePoint content (pages, metadata, and structure) as the foundation for Copilot and AI agents.

This means intranet quality directly determines AI value. A sloppy intranet will produce noisy AI results

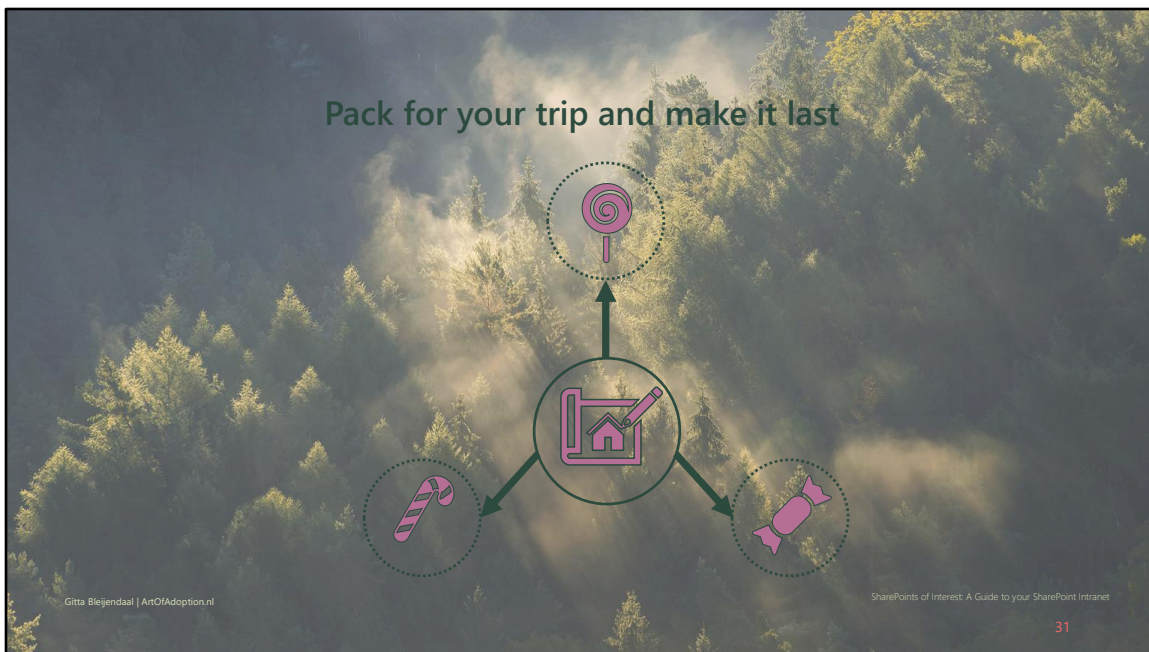


*"Pack some snacks
Take these lightweight, practical Governance tips along your journey "*

Gitta Bleijendaal | AmOfAdoption.nl

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

30



Last but not least, some snacks to pack to make your journey last longer.

Five Governance & lifecycle tips to keep your intranet healthy:

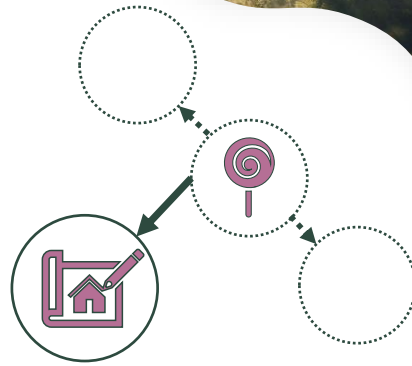
1. Ownership
2. Review moments
3. Archiving with intention
4. Decentralized publishing with centralized standards
5. Measure relevance

"Pack for your trip and make it last longer"

Packing | 5 Governance & lifecycle tips

1. Lightweight and practical tips:

1. Every page needs an owner.
2. Build review moments into content, not cleanup projects.
3. Archive with intention, not fear
4. Decentralize publishing, centralize standards.
5. Measure relevance, not just activity



Gitta Benthien / Shutterstock

SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

32

1. Some lightweight and practical Governance and lifecycle tips to make your intranet journey last longer:

1. Every page needs at least one owner. Not just on paper in permissions, but in actions and with assigned tasks. Ownership builds trust, for users and for Copilot.
2. Build review moments into content, not into big cleanup projects. Small, regular reviews beat massive cleanup efforts. Support this by designing and building it into your structures and metadata.
3. Archive with intention and not with fear. Stop hoarding. Keeping everything "just in case" hurts findability and AI quality.
4. Decentralize publishing, centralize standards. Let your teams contribute, but within shared patterns and guardrails. Make sure you have communicated these and have made them available.
5. Measure relevance, not just activity. Focus on search success, repeat visits, and trusted content and not page views.

"Every intranet journey is different"

Guide's Recap

1. A modern intranet starts with clear goals, not features.
2. One intranet $\neq$ one experience. Design for roles, context, and moments.
3. Information Architecture is the foundation for both usability and AI.
4. Editorial processes are guardrails, not bureaucracy.
5. Copilot amplifies what's already there: good or bad.
6. Technology, people, and processes must move together to stay relevant.

"Plan, well, pack smart, and walk it together"

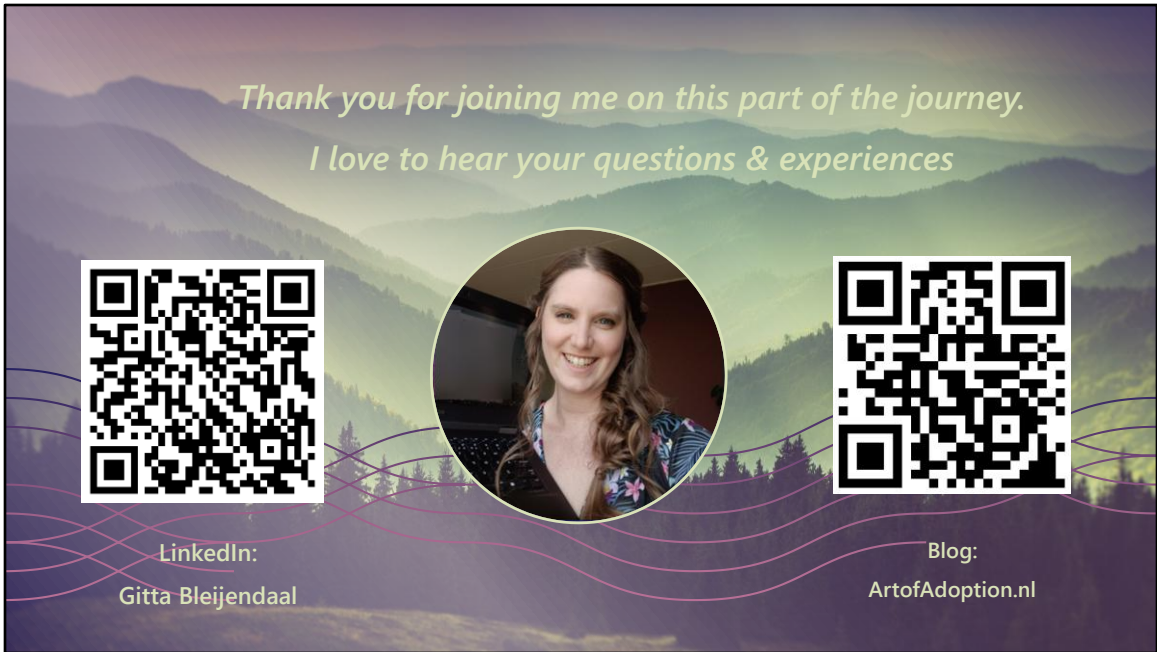
Gitte Bleijendaal | ArtofAdoption.nl



SharePoints of Interest: A Guide to your SharePoint Intranet

A great SharePoint intranet isn't something you launch once. It is a journey you actively guide.

And you plan it well, pack smart, and walk it together, Copilot becomes a powerful travel companion instead of a noisy tourist.



Thank you for joining me on this part of the journey. I hope it gave you a few ideas to take back to your own intranet. Now I'd love to hear your questions or experiences.